

RECLAIMING THE TAJ

Several right-wing outfits insist Taj Mahal was a Shiva temple to begin with

May 2017: Protest by activists of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad and Bajrang Dal, saying that the Taj Mahal was actually a Shiva temple. Later, some of them wearing saffron clothes enter the Taj Mahal against the rules

Nov. 2018: Meena Diwakar, the district president of the women's wing of the Bajrang Dal, tries to perform an aarti inside the mosque in the Taj Mahal. Police register an FIR against Diwakar

Jan. 2021: Four activists of the Hindu Jagran Manch are arrested for waving saffron flags while reciting Shiv Chalisa on the Taj Mahal premises. They are released on bail from the court

Apr. 26, 2022: Mahant Paramhans Das of Ayodhya's Tapasvi Chhavni visits the Taj with a 'brahmadand' (religious penalty) wrapped in saffron cloth. He is not allowed entry, sparking protests by Hindu organisations the next day

May 3: Paramhans Das, who described the Taj Mahal as Tejo Mahalaya, visits Agra again

May 5: Das announces land worship and purification in the Taj Mahal. The police send him back to Ayodhya after putting him under house arrest

May 7: BJP leader Rajnish Singh files a petition in the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court, seeking a direction to the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to open the 22 locked rooms inside the Taj Mahal

May 12: The high court dismisses the plea, saying the petitioner filed it in a "casual" manner and failed to point out which of his legal or constitutional rights were being infringed upon. The ASI had told an Agra court in 2017 that there was no evidence that a temple ever existed at the site of the Mughal mausoleum

EVER SINCE THE BJP CAME TO POWER IN UP, THE DEMAND TO CHANGE THE NAMES OF ROADS, PARKS, MONUMENTS IN AGRA HAS RISEN RAPIDLY; SOME HAVE BEEN RENAMED TOO

expected a faster completion of the construction work after the renaming, but it did not even resume.

The Yogi government, which returned to power in March 2022, is now mooting a public-private partnership model for the museum. Before that, however, the project will be redesigned. Dilip Singh, the project manager of the Rajkiya Nirman Nigam, the executive body for museum construction, says, "We have sent a letter to the government informing it about the status of the project. The construction will start as soon as the budget is received."

Not everyone in Agra, though, is happy with the renaming agenda. "The Taj Mahal," says Rajiv Saxena, vice-president of the Tourism Guild of Agra, "is one of the wonders of the world. It is shameful to do politics in the name of a monument monitored by the Supreme Court and Unesco. This is tarnishing India's image." K.C. Jain, Supreme Court advocate and secretary of the Agra Development Foundation, agrees: "In the past five years, the government has not approved a single new hotel in the city, whereas unprovoked disputes are being created over the Taj Mahal. This is adding to the crisis in the tourism industry."

Many development plans have indeed been hanging fire. Among these is the rubber check dam project to conserve the Taj. Chief Minister Yogi had in 2017 announced the construction of a barrage downstream of the Yamuna, 1.5 km from the monument. An official of the irrigation department, who did not want to be identified, says, "For a long time, the project swung between the barrage and the rubber dam before the government agreed to the latter." A sum of Rs 413 crore was estimated to be spent on the 344-metre-long dam to be built in Nagla Paima village. The government earmarked Rs 50 crore for it in the 2018-19 budget, followed by Rs 6 crore the next year, and Rs 100 crore in 2020-21. So, Rs 156 crore has lapsed as the work couldn't start. In the current financial year, the government has made a provision of Rs 20 crore for the dam. According to Tarun Sharma, an assistant professor of history at the Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar University in Agra, the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) has stipulated the water level be 148 metres in the Yamuna behind the Taj Mahal. This would ensure that its foundation continues to get moisture, which is important for the monument's protection. But the construction is dogged by constant delay, baffling conservationists.

In response to an RTI query by environmental activist Debashish Bhattacharya, the irrigation department on August 26 replied that they have got permission to build the dam from the Inland Waterways Authority of India, the Central Water Commission, the ASI and the National Environmental Engineering Research Institute. Earlier in April, the Taj Trapezium Zone Authority—mandated to protect the monument—had consented to the dam. However, the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority has not yet studied the project. This is further delaying permissions from the Union environment ministry and the National Mission for Clean Ganga. Higher education Minister and Agra Southern MLA Yogendra Upadhyay says, "The construction work will start soon. Efforts have been intensified to get NOC from all departments." He has also requested the chief minister to remove the obstacles in the construction of various other projects. Until that happens development will remain hostage to political imperative. ■